

Average Rate of Change

ANSWER KEY



Computing average rate of change

- 1 Find the average rate of change of $f(x) = x^2$ over each interval:

a $[0, 2] = 2$

b $[1, 3] = 4$

c $[2, 5] = 7$

d $[-1, 1] = 0$

- 2 Find the average rate of change of $f(x) = 2^x$ over the interval $[0, 3]$.

$$\frac{f(3) - f(0)}{3 - 0} = \frac{8 - 1}{3} = \frac{7}{3}.$$

- 3 Show that the average rate of change of $g(x) = 3x - 5$ is the same over any interval $[a, b]$, and state its value.

$$\frac{g(b) - g(a)}{b - a} = \frac{(3b - 5) - (3a - 5)}{b - a} = \frac{3(b - a)}{b - a} = 3. \text{ A linear function changes at a constant rate equal to its slope.}$$

Applications

- 4 A ball is thrown upward so that its height after t seconds is $h(t) = -5t^2 + 20t$ meters.

a Find the average rate of change of the height over $[0, 2]$. $\frac{h(2) - h(0)}{2 - 0} = \frac{20 - 0}{2} = 10$ m/s.

b Find the average rate of change of the height over $[1, 3]$. $h(1) = 15$ and $h(3) = 15$, so the average rate of change is $\frac{15 - 15}{2} = 0$ m/s.

c Interpret your answer to part b in the context of the ball's motion. Over $[1, 3]$ the ball rises and then falls back to the same height, so on average its height does not change.

- 5 The graph of $f(x) = -\frac{1}{2}x^2 + 2x + 1$ is shown. Estimate the average rate of change over $[0, 4]$, then verify your estimate algebraically.

$f(0) = 1$ and $f(4) = -8 + 8 + 1 = 1$, so the average rate of change over $[0, 4]$ is $\frac{1 - 1}{4} = 0$. The secant line through the endpoints is horizontal.